

HAD INDIA INADVERTENTLY HIT A NUCLEAR STORAGE SITE, PAKISTAN WOULD HAVE TREATED IT AS FIRST STRIKE AND RETALIATED WITH NUCLEAR WEAPONS

India and possesses the largest and most diversified nuclear arsenal in the region. This is because, he says, "Pakistan is increasingly driven less by what India is actually doing and more by its fervid imaginings of India's capabilities coupled with an expansive—and expanding—notion of what its nuclear requirements entail." In the past decade, Pakistan has added tactical nuclear weapons and missiles suited for battlefield scenarios to thwart an unexpected land invasion by India. It has thus introduced a hair-trigger complexity, as the command and control of tactical weapons have to be decentralised to the brigade level for effective use during crisis, leaving the so-called nuclear button in the hands of relative juniors.

Contrary to expectations that the possession of such dangerous weapons would reduce the risk of a confrontation for fear of mutually assured destruction, the two nations have found themselves on the brink of a nuclear conflagration on three major occasions. The first was